



Ready for a bigger test: D. Gukesh bowed out in the third round. He now awaits the challenger for his World Championship title defence. ETERI KUBLASHVILI/FIDE

highest-seeded overseas player in the tournament, at No. 4, with the top three seeds being Indians: D. Gukesh, Arjun and Praggnanandhaa.

Several other big seeds were all in for disappointments, such as Wesley So (No. 5), Vincent Keymer (6), Nodirbek Abdusattorov (8), Shakhriyar Mamedyarov (9), Hans Niemann (10), Maxime Vachier-Lagrave (11) and Ian Nepomniachtchi (12). Given the knockout format, the early exits of these stars weren't all that surprising, really.

Perhaps the most popular player to be eliminated before the event reached its business end was Levon Aronian, but he ran into an in-form, higher-ranked Arjun. The Armenia-born American is not just a brilliant player and one of the highest-rated in history, but a favourite with chess fans. He greets everyone with a smile and doesn't disappoint the autograph and selfie-hunters. He has a terrific sense of humour too.

He is also something of an

Indophile: a huge admirer of Satyajit Ray's films and also loves classical Indian music. "I have been listening to Kishori Amonkar a lot lately," he told *Sportstar*, a day after his defeat to Arjun, someone he has great regard for.

Arjun's loss to Wei was a setback not just for India but for the tournament. The lack of an Indian presence in the final stages, it was feared, would diminish local interest. And that was the case. The security men, who had to ensure stars like Gukesh, Praggnanandhaa and Arjun were not disturbed while they entered or exited the playing hall, witnessed a drop in attendance for the semifinals and the final.

That India fell way short of expectations is true. But the World Cup is like that. Nobody expected Divya Deshmukh (**right**) to bring the women's World Cup to India, and yet she did, a few months ago. That is the nature of such tournaments and why they generate a lot of excitement among chess followers.



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